

An Answer on the Two-Day Weekend Question

Zhihu · 2026-09-19

This could not be shown under the original question, so I am posting it here, with a few things rephrased.

The questioner raised three questions. I shall answer them one by one.

Question 1: Can a two-day weekend for everyone be realised?

A two-day weekend for everyone can not only be realised; it will inevitably be realised. This is decided by the stage of China's economic development.

Over the past thirty years, China integrated itself into global value chains mainly by developing low- and mid-end, labour-intensive industries. China's principal competitors in industry include not only Latin America, where wages are higher than in China, but also Southeast Asia, South Asia and even Africa, where wages are lower still. In these conditions, China's main strategy was to hold down hourly wages and suppress every form of labour resistance, so as to keep attracting transnational capital and push Chinese firms into the supply chains of the world's leading enterprises. Against that strategic background, the two-day weekend was impossible, overtime — even unpaid overtime — was unavoidable, and proper compensation was very hard to obtain. This is essentially the argument of those who oppose the two-day weekend and any large rise in the minimum wage.

Of course, until capitalism has basically exhausted the surplus labour of South Asia, Southeast Asia and Africa, demands for substantial wage increases and shorter hours in labour-intensive industries really will accelerate the relocation of industry, because plenty of countries are capable of developing labour-intensive industries. The frantic rush of Chinese capital into Vietnam and India and its active positioning in Africa are clear proof. Workers' demands for higher wages — including nation-states' own moves to raise the minimum wage — are mainly about enabling wages to keep up with rising prices and with the working class's rising floor for a decent life. China's minimum wage in a first-tier city such as Shenzhen, for example, is about 2,500 yuan, whereas in 2000 it was nearly 420 yuan — a difference that broadly reflects the rise in prices.

Since the 2010s, however, China has been carrying out industrial upgrading, gradually relocating labour-intensive industry and shifting instead to mid- and high-end capital- and technology-intensive industries and to services. The economic statistics reflect this trend: traditional sectors are steadily shrinking, while the emerging sectors that represent the "new-quality productive forces" are growing

rapidly. This industrial shift means that the competitors of Chinese firms are changing from the countries of Latin America, Southeast Asia and South Asia to the advanced industrial countries of Europe, America, Japan and Korea.

The wages and labour conditions of workers in Europe, America, Japan and Korea are worlds apart from those of Southeast Asia and South Asia. In Vietnam and Indonesia they run at roughly 1,000 to 2,000-odd yuan. Even Korea, the laggard among the advanced industrial countries, has a monthly minimum wage of about 10,000 yuan. As for working hours, Korea is on the long side among developed countries, yet far shorter than Vietnam's or China's^[1].

What does this mean? The perceptive reader will already have seen it. Under the present economic system and pattern of industrial competition, Chinese workers have won unprecedented room for higher wages and shorter hours. If Chinese workers' hourly wages gradually reach 80 per cent of Korea's and their working hours come into line with Korea's, this will not much affect China's industrial competitiveness, because the labour costs of Chinese firms will still be far below the average of the developed countries.

Where labour costs are still clearly lower than competitors', if a Chinese firm cannot compete, the cause is probably insufficient fixed capital investment and low labour productivity. In that case the state can perfectly well provide special low-interest loans to help firms renew equipment and raise productivity. Productivity rising in step with shorter working hours ends in a win-win for capital and labour — at the very least capital does not lose much, while workers' living standards rise substantially and their hours fall sharply, which for the great majority of people in the country is an outright triumph. It is therefore entirely possible for China to realise a two-day weekend for all, as most advanced industrial countries have done.

Why do I say that the two-day weekend is not only possible but inevitable?

Because if China does not implement the two-day weekend, paid annual leave, a higher minimum wage and the other measures that improve workers' treatment, there are several grave harms.

The first harm is that the lack of rest time accelerates the fall in the fertility rate. This needs little elaboration: study after study has confirmed the relationship between long working hours, delayed childbearing and declining fertility. For a nation-state, population decline is fatal. Even someone like "Political Commissar" Jin, who declares victory all day long, is full of anxiety when faced with the population question. Letting the workers who make up the overwhelming majority of the population earn, within a 40-hour week, enough for subsistence and for bringing up the next generation — that is the economic precondition for slowing the fall in the fertility rate and even for turning it round.

The second harm is that low hourly wages leave domestic demand weak, which in turn makes domestic investment meagre and speeds up the outflow of industrial capital. China's present trade

surplus of more than a trillion yuan a year means, in essence, that the consumption of Chinese workers and capitalists plus firms' expanded reproduction at home cannot absorb all the goods the workers produce, so the rest must be sold abroad. A large part of the money earned from those sales goes into building plants abroad. Building plants abroad and exporting from them further is a mutually reinforcing cycle. The heat of exports and the cold of domestic demand are two sides of one problem. The remedy is to raise workers' total income, so that more of the value created in China stays in China. Once workers' incomes are higher, they will increase imports and domestically oriented production, and imports and exports will finally come into balance.

The third harm is that it weakens the basis of class cooperation and undermines social stability. This is seen from the standpoint of the leadership. For several decades China mainly relied on raising the productive forces to improve workers' living standards. Enlarging the pie, developing the productive forces — that became the basis of capital-labour cooperation. So long as workers were given jobs, society could stay stable. This is now changing. As the era in which China rapidly developed its productive forces by importing advanced technology draws to a close, ordinary technological progress alone is no longer enough to raise workers' living standards. Workers are beginning to turn their eyes to the sphere of distribution: working hours, the minimum wage and the like. If those in power do not respond to the masses' demands, the basis of class cooperation will be gradually eroded, and in the end it will give rise to direct class confrontation.

Therefore, in the long run a normal working week is bound to be realised. This process is closely bound up with the revival of reformism in the advanced industrial countries (see "The Prospects of Reformism" and "Before 2055, Which Other Countries Might Become Developed Countries?").

Question 2: What is the greatest difficulty in realising the two-day weekend?

There are three main difficulties.

First, the outright opposition of capital. Enterprises certainly do not want anyone to enforce a normal working week. Whether private owners or senior executives, they inevitably express the drive of capital to self-expand. Any demand from workers in this area is, in their eyes, rank insubordination. In their view, it is the enterprise that gives workers their jobs; without the enterprise you would have starved long ago, and you still dare to raise such demands. They are therefore the greatest obstacle to the two-day weekend.

Second, the outlook of those in power. In their eyes the workers of China are essentially peasants who have come to the cities. On the evidence of their own lives, it is already good enough to eat your fill and dress warmly; so what if the hours are a little long? After all, thirty years ago most families were

thankful to eat meat once a week. The situation now, they think, is that the work is tiring but you have food, drink and a roof over your head — so what is there to complain about? To them, "Buddhist-style indifference" and "lying flat" are all the result of Western influence, and they find it hard to understand why young people think this way.

Third, the weakness of the workers. In principle the workers are many and their demands are clear, so they should easily get what they want. But the recent affair of the two-day-weekend mini-programme exposed a crucial problem. The labouring masses are a heap of loose sand, and every means of uniting workers is very hard to keep alive in the present environment. There is not much I can say about this. But if these restrictions are not lifted, then in the long run it is bound to put those in power in opposition to the masses. Opposition accumulates, and in the end it will certainly force change. Whether that change is peaceful or not depends on the wisdom of those at the top.

Question 3: As a wage-earner, how can I effectively promote the two-day weekend?

It is impossible for an individual to systematically promote the realisation of the two-day weekend. But that does not mean nothing can be done; there are some positive things one can do.

First, use the existing space of online public opinion to express your views. Do not aim high while your hands stay low, and do not disdain small acts of good. Sincerely expressing your own opinion breaks no law, and it has an effect.

Second, do not actively undermine the two-day weekend and the normal working week. When your workplace does not require you to work overtime, do not rush to work overtime to earn credit. Of course, if most people go, there is nothing to be done and you can only follow the crowd. But so long as a fair number of people still hold the line, we should not go and play the scab.

Finally, if a large-scale movement demanding the two-day weekend appears in your own workplace and many people have already joined it, you may consider joining too. After all, when so many people are taking part, could someone who knows enough to ask how to promote the two-day weekend just stand by with folded arms? Still, there is no need to worry: the chance of any one person encountering such a thing is very low, and taking part once is a way to enrich your life experience.

Notes

[1] List of countries by average annual labor hours

中文原文：List of countries by average annual labor hours

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_countries_by_average_annual_labor_hours

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